

TREE OF THOUGHT

Three options. One **clear** **next move.**

A three-step prompt sequence for ChatGPT or DeepSeek.
With a practical, start-to-finish example.

Adapted from Sabrina Ramonov's tutorial
Guide and worked example by Stefanie Zucker

Start here. Then explore.

Use this when you have a real decision to make and several possible ways forward. You will explore three options, evaluate them, then choose a small next step.

Open one new chat in ChatGPT or DeepSeek. Replace the bracketed fields below. Send Prompt 1, wait for the answer, then send Prompts 2 and 3 separately in the **same conversation**.

Prompt 1 / Explore three different approaches

Help me explore a problem before choosing a solution.

PROBLEM: [Describe the decision and the result you want.]

CONTEXT: [Add your starting point, audience, deadline, budget, available time, and non-negotiables.]

If essential information is missing, ask me for it first.

Then propose three genuinely different approaches, not three versions of the same idea.

For each approach, give it a short name, explain how it works, and identify the main trade-off. Consider different perspectives and practical alternatives. Stay within my constraints. Label assumptions. Do not choose a winner yet.

Make the context useful

State the outcome, deadline, available time, budget, and what you will not compromise. "Help me grow" gives the model less to work with than "Help me choose one way to win three clients in 30 days with five hours a week."

This is a structured comparison exercise. You do not need to switch apps if you already use ChatGPT.

Prompts adapted from [Sabrina Ramonov's Tree of Thought tutorial](#). Guide and worked example by Stefanie Zucker / Zucker Digital.

Evaluate. Then choose.

Continue in the same chat after receiving the three options. Paste each prompt separately and wait for its answer.

Prompt 2 / Compare the trade-offs

Evaluate the three approaches from your last answer using my stated goal and constraints.

For each, explain:

1. The main benefit and why it could work.
2. The weaknesses and risks.
3. The time, money, skills, and other resources needed.
4. Likely roadblocks and what could make it fail.
5. A favorable scenario and an unfavorable scenario.
6. What evidence would increase or reduce confidence in it.

Separate facts from estimates. Label unknowns. Do not invent precise success probabilities. Finish with a comparison table.

Prompt 3 / Pick a testable next move

Use that comparison to rank the three approaches from best fit to weakest fit for my goal and constraints.

For each ranking, give a concise justification based on feasibility, likely impact, and the balance of risk and reward. Explain what new information could change the order.

Recommend one approach to test first. Suggest a refinement or combination only if it stays within my constraints. Give me a concrete first-week plan, one signal to track, and a checkpoint for deciding whether to continue or adjust. Do not present an estimate as a guaranteed result.

Read the recommendation against your real constraints. Correct any invented facts or unrealistic estimates before acting.

Illustrative scenario: a solo bookkeeper choosing how to attract three new clients. The sample responses on these pages are teaching examples, not results from a real business or a measured AI test.

Put this context into Prompt 1

PROBLEM: I run a solo bookkeeping business. I want to sign three new monthly clients in the next 30 days.

CONTEXT: I serve independent consultants. I can spend five hours a week and up to \$150 total on this effort. I have ten happy current clients and twenty former prospects I may appropriately contact. I have no paid-ad experience and no large social audience. I can comfortably onboard three clients. I will not discount my monthly fee.

Step 1: Three meaningfully different options

A / Personal referrals and warm follow-up.

Ask happy clients for a relevant introduction and reconnect with former prospects. Offer a short fit call. This uses existing trust but depends on the network having a current need.

B / One focused online workshop.

Host a short session on getting consulting-business books ready for month-end. Invite relevant contacts and offer a fit call afterward. It demonstrates expertise, but requires preparation and an audience.

C / Referral partnerships.

Approach tax preparers or business advisers who already serve consultants. Explore mutual introductions. It can create repeat referrals, but relationship-building may take longer than 30 days.

These are different routes: existing relationships, teaching, and partnerships. Three versions of a social post would not create the same useful comparison.

Worked example / Make the call

Step 2: Evaluate the options. These first-week time and cash estimates are illustrative planning assumptions. Confidence describes fit with the stated constraints, not the chance of signing three clients.

Option	Resources + benefit	Risk + confidence
A / Warm outreach	4–5 hours; \$0. Fast to begin; existing trust.	Contacts may not need help now. Strongest near-term fit; demand remains unknown.
B / Workshop	5 hours; \$0–\$50. Shows expertise to several people at once.	Preparation uses the week's time; attendance uncertain. Weaker fit without an audience.
C / Partners	4–5 hours; \$0. Potential for repeated introductions.	Trust and introductions take time. Useful longer term; less certain within 30 days.

Scenario check: A works well if contacts introduce someone with an immediate need; it stalls if nobody is looking. B works with an engaged invite list; it stalls with low attendance. C works with an interested adviser; it stalls if building trust takes several weeks.

Step 3: Rank, choose, and test

- 1. A / Warm outreach.** Best first test because the business already has trusted relationships, and starting does not require cash or a new audience.
- 2. C / Partnerships.** A useful next route if warm outreach produces few qualified conversations.
- 3. B / Workshop.** Revisit when there is an audience or a partner willing to invite one.

What would change the ranking? A partner with an engaged consultant audience and a firm event date could make the workshop more attractive.

A five-hour first-week plan

- 1 hour:** Select five current clients and five former prospects whose needs fit the service.
- 2 hours:** Send ten personal messages asking for a relevant introduction or a short fit conversation.
- 1 hour:** Reply and follow up appropriately.
- 1 hour:** Reserve two 30-minute fit calls; use unused time to review responses.

Track: qualified conversations booked. **Day-seven checkpoint:** if at least two are booked, continue the test. If not, review the audience, message, and replies before switching routes. Two conversations are a test signal, not a promise of three clients.

Three-step approach: Sabrina Ramonov. Scenario, adapted prompts, and illustrative analysis: Stefanie Zucker / Zucker Digital.